

Oracle may be the best friend open source and Linux will ever have. Shane Owenby, director, Linux & Open Source, Asia Pacific, Oracle, earlier told us in an interview, "Our developers internally develop on Linux, so there's quite a lot of momentum there. There is something called 'Oracle on Demand', where Oracle runs an Oracle customer's Oracle software for them—we run that on Linux. So, we trust Linux that much."

Greg Kroah-Hartman, the current Linux kernel maintainer for the stable branch, admits, "They have contributed a lot. See the articles about Linux kernel development on LWN.net for every kernel release, for the details on exactly how many contributions they have made, and where they are."

But will the acquisition of Solaris affect the development of Linux? Chris Mason, a developer from Oracle's Linux kernel team and the primary author of Btrfs (the filesystem project to replace ext3 as the preferred filesystem on Linux), notes, "Oracle has been heavily using and contributing to Linux for a long time, and all of our public statements around Sun have talked about how Linux is still important to us. In terms of projects done by people on my Linux Kernel team, we don't expect

any decrease in our contributions."

"I expect Oracle's work on Btrfs to remain unchanged. The work the Oracle kernel team does is top-notch and is likely to expand," Zemlin hopes.

There is another possibility. Since Oracle now owns Solaris it can change its licence to make it compatible with Linux, allowing code to be shared between the two projects. This way it will be able to port missing features of one operating system to another which, in turn, will eventually improve both the products. Zemlin's statement seems to echo this, "We would love to see Solaris under a GPLv2 licence... This would be a win for users of both platforms." [The open source Solaris project, OpenSolaris, is licensed under CDDL, a licence which is incompatible with the GPLv2 licence that Linux uses.]

Whether Oracle relicenses Solaris or not, either way it's a win-win for Oracle, at least. There seems to be no valid reason for Oracle to decrease its contribution to Linux, which has become very powerful and popular in the server segment.

So, what now remains unanswered is the future of the core open source technologies that Sun had developed or acquired over time. Some of the

technologies seem to compete with Oracle's line of products. Will Oracle sell them off, kill them or polish them to enter the markets it is absent in?

"We would be happy to cooperate very closely with Oracle but we are not likely to join. After working for a big company like Sun, we enjoy the extra freedom and benefits we get in a smaller company. Another thing is that I don't think Oracle can match the benefits of the hacking business model we have been using."

—Monty Widenius, co-founder, MySQL

"Oracle has a strong business interest in supporting Linux"

...according to Jim Zemlin, executive director, The Linux Foundation.

Q. What is the general sentiment within the Linux community post this acquisition?
Jim Zemlin: Generally positive, but let's wait and see. The deal still needs to be finalised and there are many questions about what will become of the many important open source projects like OpenOffice.org and others.

Q. Are you in touch with Oracle or Ellison to discuss the future of Linux and Solaris?

JZ: I work closely with Ellison's staff, particularly with Wim Coekaerts, who's Oracle's vice president of Linux engineering, and also a member of the Linux Foundation board of directors.

Q. Oracle and Microsoft are both proprietary companies. How much honesty or genuine effort do you see from each side in terms of supporting Linux?

JZ: Oracle has a strong business interest in supporting Linux. It is run on Linux, it offers Linux products and services, and its primary development platform is Linux. Regardless of whether or not Oracle offers proprietary software, it has a strategic interest in supporting Linux. Microsoft, alternatively, has little business interest in supporting a competitive platform that it does not use at all. It does have an interest in promoting interoperability between Linux and Microsoft products in order to respond to customer demands. The company is doing this in Sam Ramji's group at Microsoft, and we often collaborate with them on various issues that are beneficial to both parties.

